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Never Judge a Person by *His, His or Her, or Their* Appearance? Spotlighting the Use of Epicene Pronouns by Chinese Learners of English

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Introduction

Gender equality is a central objective of the Sustainable Development Goals established by the United Nations to foster global citizenship. This also arises as a significant concern in the broad field of education (Aikman et al., 2011; Rosa & Clavero, 2022), because gender inequalities have been shown to impact student academic achievements negatively (Zhang et al., 2024). Language education is no exception (Cheng & Ghajarieh, 2009; Widodo & Elyas, 2020). The interplay of gender equality and language can be understood through two points of agreement. First, gender and language are socially constructed (Edwards, 2006; Lorber, 2018), meaning that both can change in response to social factors. Second, gender (in)equalities can be expressed through linguistic means (Formanowicz & Hansen, 2022), as these linguistic forms influence how individuals of a particular gender are internally represented. Fairclough (2013) also underscores this connection, indicating that language and social practice – including gender practice – are mutually reflected and reinforced.

In relation to gender equality, the English language presents an interesting case because it lacks a third-person singular gender-neutral pronoun that refers to an individual of no gender assignment (Baron, 2020). Various attempts have thus been made to address this lexical gap, with the most commonly used pronouns, also known as epicene pronouns, being the generic *he*, *he or she*, and singular *they* (Stormbom, 2024; Zhang & Yang, 2024). Using these pronouns in non-gender-specified contexts may reasonably reveal language users' stance on gender equality. In this study, we analyzed such pronouns adopted by Chinese learners of English as a foreign language (EFL) in their essay writing and then compared our findings with those from a previous study based on earlier data to identify any evolving pattern regarding the use of epicene pronouns.

In the following sections, we first introduce these epicene pronouns, examining their inter-relationships and discussing their significance among language users. We then briefly review the literature on how learners of English as a second language (L2) comprehend and produce these pronouns. Following this, we report a small-scale corpus investigation into the use of these pronouns by Chinese EFL learners in their essay writing, which



forms part of our larger research project. Finally, we propose instructional strategies usable in EFL settings for effectively incorporating these pronouns into language education.

Literature Review

English Epicene Pronouns

Three pronouns frequently used to refer to an individual of unknown gender have been highlighted in the literature. The first option is generic *he*¹. However, generic *he* is not always truly generic, as its use diminishes the representation of females in gender-non-specific contexts (Miller & James, 2009). In addition, the use of generic *he* can reinforce certain social stereotypes. As shown in Example (a), portraying a criminal as male by default may perpetuate the stereotype that men are more likely to engage in criminal behavior.

- (a) ... a criminal was sentenced to death ... his family could be entangled into multitudes of prejudice and humiliation.[Learner Corpus²]

The second option is the construction *he or she*³, which emerged in response to criticisms of generic *he*. While this construction includes both genders, it still operates under the binary gender assumptions, marginalizing non-binary individuals. Since it simply elevates female representation, the *he or she* construction serves more of a strategy for gender “feminization” rather than “neutralization” (Stormbom, 2024, p. 412).

To accommodate the full spectrum of gender identities, scholars have extensively explored alternatives to the construction *he or she*. Proposed replacements include *ze*, *xe*, *hir*, *she*, and singular *they*, among others (see Baron, 2020, for a chronological list of epicene pronouns). Of these, singular *they* has garnered widespread acceptance as a genuine gender-neutral solution in English-as-a-first-language communities (LaScotte, 2016; Paterson, 2014) and part of the English-as-a-second-language communities (Ebrahimi & Hosseini, 2021; Stojanovska-Ilievska, 2024; Stormbom, 2019, 2022). This pronoun avoids privileging any particular gender or adhering to the gender-binary framework, akin to the shift from *policeman* to *police officer*. Stormbom (2022) advocates for a modification to the current English pronominal paradigm to include singular *they* as a third-person singular gender-unspecified pronoun, parallel to masculine *he* and feminine *she*.

Figure 1 illustrates the relationships among these three epicene pronouns. Notably, these pronouns are not positioned equally, with singular *they* perceived as the most inclusive option. It is essential to recognize that generic *he* and *he or she* were originally introduced as gender-neutral pronouns but have gradually fallen out of favor due to their inability to accurately reflect the evolving social dynamics.

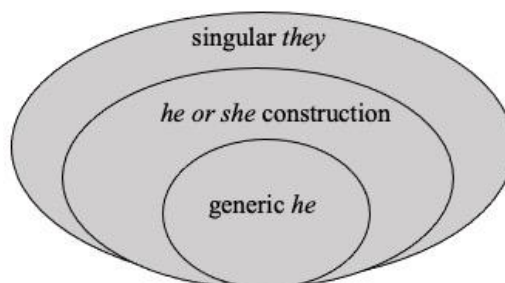


Figure 1. The inter-relationships among the three epicene pronouns.

The Importance of English Epicene Pronouns

The use of epicene pronouns has long been an intensely debated topic, drawing researchers together from the fields of (second) language acquisition and gender studies. Its significance can be approached through a theoretical lens and practical needs. According to the linguistic relativity hypothesis, the language we speak shapes or reshapes our cognitive processes and influences our perception of the world (Lucy, 1997). As such, exposure to gendered and exclusionary use of pronouns, exemplified by generic *he* and *he or she*, may exacerbate male dominance and the binary-gender construct, potentially resulting in greater gender inequalities.

From a practical standpoint, as English has established itself as a dominant global language and international communication has become more accessible, prompted by the emergence of digital tools, learners are increasingly exposed to a range of individual identities, including fluid gender identities. In today's multicultural and globalized society, characterized partly by the heightened visibility of gender non-conforming individuals, including those who identify as lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and queer (Fiani & Han, 2020), it is essential to educate students about gender-neutral language practices that aim to respect gender diversity and promote gender equality. One of these initiatives is the adoption of singular *they*, as opposed to generic *he* and *he or she*. The inclusion of gender perspectives in language education is integral to the development of intercultural competence (Velázquez-Lora, 2022), a component that English language curricula have long sought to strengthen.

Second Language Learners' Use of Epicene Pronouns

While there is general support for the use of singular *they* among English-as-first-language users (Baranowski, 2002; Bradley et al., 2019; LaScotte, 2016; Paterson, 2014; Paulwels, 2001), considerable variations exist among learners. Several studies indicate that learners mainly relied on generic *he* to refer to an individual without specific gender (Abudalbh, 2012; Lee, 2007, 2015; Stormbom, 2018; Zhang & Yang, 2021), while some research revealed that *he or she* was the most frequently used epicene pronoun among learners (Zhang et al., 2020; Zhang and Yang, 2024). In contrast, more recent studies demonstrated an increasing tendency for learners to predominantly utilize singular *they* in gender-neutral contexts (Ebrahimi & Hosseini, 2021; Reilly-Thornton, 2021; Stojanovska-Ilievska, 2024; Stormbom, 2019, 2022).

Regarding participant backgrounds, Chinese EFL learners demonstrated varying preferences for epicene pronoun usage, which necessitates further investigation. For example, Lee (2015) utilized story continuation tasks to elicit the epicene pronoun used by Chinese learners when referring anaphorically to a gender-determinate individual like a *manager*, *employee*, or *professor*. The findings revealed that the majority of learners preferred generic *he*, with minimal consideration for singular *they*. Employing other elicitation instruments such as multiple-choice tests, Zhang et al. (2020) and Zhang and Yang (2024) found that learners predominantly opted for *he or she* as their preferred epicene pronoun.

While elicitation methods yield focused data, providing limited insights into learners' actual use of epicene pronouns, corpus analysis enables more authentic examinations of pronoun usage. Zhang and Yang (2021) conducted a corpus query by analyzing English essays written by Chinese learners and found generic *he* to be the most popular choice (60%), significantly surpassing *he or she* (25%) and singular *they* (15%). It is important to note that all essays in the corpus were collected between 2003 and 2007, thus reflecting usage patterns during that period. Therefore, studies drawing on more recent corpora are warranted to capture current trends in epicene pronoun usage among Chinese EFL learners.

To address this need, we conducted a small-scale corpus investigation in the current study into the use of epicene pronouns – generic *he*, *he or she*, and singular *they* – among Chinese learners, which is part of our larger project examining the linguistic, learner, and contextual factors influencing Chinese learners' use of

epicene pronouns. Our focus on this demographic is motivated by two considerations. First, Chinese learners represent the world's largest English learner population (Jiang, 2003), a group that may contribute significantly to gender equality among English-learning communities, particularly in the digital era where cross-border communication has become increasingly prevalent. Therefore, understanding their use of these pronouns is crucial. Second, we utilize a more recent corpus to examine epicene pronoun usage and compare our results with those of Zhang and Yang (2021), who also studied this demographic but relied on earlier data. The research question guiding this study is as follows: Which epicene pronoun did Chinese learners predominantly use in their essay writing?

Method

Corpus and Data Preparation

Our analysis of epicene pronouns draws on the *iWriteBaby Chinese Learners' English Corpus*⁴, which includes an ample collection of non-academic English essays written by Chinese EFL learners from 154 majors across 69 universities between 2010 and 2019. This corpus comprises over nine million words and contains more than 50,000 essays in response to 1,000 writing prompts.

We searched the corpus using *a person* as the keyword, yielding 2,115 matches across 1,707 unique essays. We then exported each instance that included the keyword *a person* and a 100-word context distributed equally to the left and right of the keyword, along with an identifying number assigned to each essay. For each instance, this 100-word context provided adequate information to examine the presence of epicene pronouns – generic *he*, *he or she*, singular *they*, and their objective/possessive/reflective forms.

Data Coding and Analysis

Since all instances were generated from free writing, it was necessary to conduct data cleaning to ensure that (i) the keyword *a person* represented a third-party individual with no gender assignment and (ii) a third-person pronoun established a referential relationship with the keyword *a person* within the context. We excluded instances where

- no pronoun was used to refer to *a person*.
- first-person or second-person pronouns were used to reference *a person*.
- *a person* represented a specific individual with the gender assigned.
- different epicene pronouns were used to refer to *a person* within an instance.

With these exclusion criteria in mind, the first author and an assistant undertook the coding in a word processor document. Each of them independently coded 10% of the data and resolved any discrepancies until reaching full agreement. The first author then continued to code the remaining data. Once the data coding was done, we employed two counting methods based on the number of instances and essays.

Specifically, we first calculated the total number of instances containing epicene pronouns. It was worth noting that following Stojanovska-Ilievska (2024), instances that included two or more epicene pronouns were counted only once in our study, because when multiple pronouns appeared referring back to the same antecedent *a person* within the same instance, as shown in Example (b), counting them multiple times could overestimate the actual occurrences.

As a second approach, we also tallied the number of unique essays (identified by their assigned number) where these epicene pronouns occurred. This approach was employed to further mitigate potential overestimation, as an essay may contain multiple instances of *a person*, and the writer of the same essay may consistently adopt the same epicene pronoun. Examples (c) and (d) illustrate this point, with either (c) or (d) being counted, but not both.

- (b) ... If a person just dreams of becoming successful after one night without pain, he would get nothing; without diligence, how can he get achievement?... (PT000343⁵)
- (c) ... a person who may always have the power to do something, and even in the free time, he also finds something to do or learn something to improve himself... (PT017034)
- (d) ... In a word, a person who has good qualities may use the most of the time to improve himself... (PT017034)

Results and Discussion

The results are visually presented in Figure 2. Notably, we identified five instances of generic *she*, which were excluded due to their limited occurrences. In all instances where two or more epicene pronouns were used, learners used the same type of epicene pronouns such as *he/his*, *they/them*, and therefore all instances were kept. However, 11 essays were discarded from the essay count approach due to the use of different epicene pronouns within an essay.

A total of 552 instances containing at least one epicene pronoun distributed across 460 unique essays were ultimately identified. Among these, 449 essays that included one epicene pronoun or consistently used multiple epicene pronouns were obtained. We ran two chi-square tests and showed that generic *he* was predominantly adopted as the preferred epicene pronoun among Chinese EFL learners (77%), overwhelmingly outnumbering singular *they* (13%) and *he or she* construction (10%) for both the instance count ($\chi^2 = 466.45$, $df = 2$, $p < .001$) and the essay count ($\chi^2 = 390.93$, $df = 2$, $p < .001$) analyses.

Overall, the prevalent use of generic *he* in the current study aligns with the findings of Zhang and Yang's (2021) corpus analysis of essays written between 2003 and 2007. What appears to be more worrying, however, is that learners in our study applied generic *he* even more frequently than those in Zhang and Yang's (2021) study. In tandem with the increased instances of generic *he* was a sharp decline in the use of *he or she* from 25% in Zhang and Yang's research to 10% in our study. In contrast, the usage proportion of singular *they* remained relatively stable across both studies, indicating little change in its adoption taking place over time.

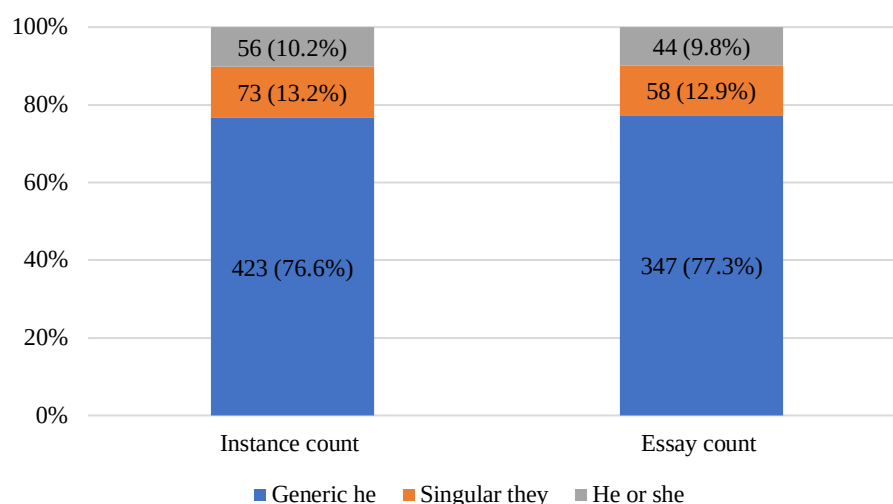


Figure 2. Distribution of occurrences across pronoun types.

We identified 64 instances that conveyed the notion of “*never judging a person by appearance*.” As shown in Examples (e) through (g) below, 44 instances employed generic *he*, 19 instances utilized singular *they*, and one instance featured *he or she*. This distribution suggests that the use of epicene pronouns seemed to be somewhat detached from specific contexts and instead reflected an individual preference. On a positive note, the modest presence of singular *they* indicates a shift towards a more inclusive language may be underway, even amidst the predominance of generic *he*.

- (e) ...it is important that you think more of others than of yourself and never judge a person by his appearance and clothes... [PT064620]
- (f) ...it is unwise to judge a person only by their appearance... [PT007521]
- (g) ...a person is like a book, never to judge his or her good or bad by the cover... [PT009732]

Importantly, our study aimed to describe rather than critique the pronoun usage patterns among Chinese learners, as we acknowledged the entrenched influence of male dominance in the prescriptive tradition of English; that is, English grammar was originally written by men for the edification of other men, primarily addressing male concerns from male standpoints (Stanley, 1978). Not surprisingly, textbooks, which serve as one of the major sources of language input for learners, have been compiled following this androcentric legacy. To compound the matter further, China’s long-standing tradition of male-centric societal norms may also encourage the use of the masculine generic *he* and prevent the acceptance of more inclusive English pronouns such as singular *they*. We should, nevertheless, be mindful of the potentially harmful consequences these gendered linguistic practices, whether intended or not, may provoke. For example, similar to Example (a), Example (h) and (i) from our data imply that men are potentially perceived to be dangerous under certain circumstances. However, *doing dangerous things* and *smoking* are not inherently associated with males. Example (j) erases female referents, which could deliver an impression that women lack the means to travel abroad. Collectively, these examples drawn from our data implicitly trigger biases towards males or females, reproduce gender inequalities, and marginalize non-binary groups. To embrace the full scope of gender identities, singular *they* should be the pronoun of choice in these instances.

- (h) ...human flesh search will cause panic in society and make a person go to the extreme, then he will do more dangerous things to hurt others and society. [PT015489]
- (i) ...At the time when a person is smoking in public, all the people who stay with him will take in the noxious smoke so that their lungs and hearts will be infected. [ZD004537]
- (j) ...When a person is traveling abroad, his behavior is not only for himself but also for his country...His behavior will influence other's perceptions of his country. [PT040900]

Conclusion and Pedagogical Implications

Our corpus investigation into epicene pronouns referring anaphorically to *a person* as an individual of unknown gender revealed that Chinese EFL learners predominantly employed generic *he*. Given such a sizeable learner population, this situation warrants scholarly attention. Although our findings are based on essays contributed by Chinese learners, the discussion of this gender issue extends to various other English learning contexts. Considering the influence of the language we use on our cognition, mind, and culture – as the linguistic relativity hypothesis posits – it is essential to incorporate epicene pronouns and, more broadly, gender perspectives into pedagogy.

Previous research that explored pedagogical strategies has primarily focused on broader aspects, such as developing gender-themed instructional materials (Tarrayo, 2023) and seeking authentic resources like TV programs and social media (Velázquez-Lora, 2022). However, we believe that these approaches are insufficient in the EFL classroom setting. An explicit focus on the epicene pronouns is needed. As such, we propose two complementary approaches integrating *reflection* and *action* with a particular focus on language.

The first approach emphasizes bottom-up reflections (from language use to social context), urging teachers to combine corpus linguistics and textual analysis techniques to critically assess current linguistic practices related to gender, similar to what we did in this study, and then seek the social forces behind these gendered practices. In addition, it is also pedagogically valuable to examine whether the valence of discourse contexts – positive, neutral, and negative – leans toward certain pronouns, potentially favoring or harming social groups represented by these pronouns. Students should also be encouraged to question and challenge common gender stereotypes to foster critical thinking about gender issues and cultivate gender awareness. A useful starting point could include the examination of job titles like *policeman* and *fireman*.

The second approach features top-down actions (from social context to language use). Instructors may begin by exploring the social dynamics that have shaped our understanding of gender and then transition to the evolving epicene pronouns driven by these social movements. Discussions should be stimulated on the (un)intended ramifications of inappropriate pronouns, which helps promote deeper engagement with pronoun usage (Stratton, 2022). Instructors could further support students by providing detailed and timely feedback on their use of epicene pronouns.

In conclusion, practicing the use of singular *they* fits the grand scheme of diversity, equality, and inclusion in education. It is crucial to recognize that the ultimate goal should not only revolve around its usage but also around developing a diversified, equitable, and inclusive mindset toward various other gender practices. While this mindset should extend beyond the English language learning context, English offers a valuable ground to nurture awareness of gender equality transferable across many other languages.

Notes

1. It includes other grammatical variants as well, including *him*, *his*, and *himself*.

2. This sentence was sourced from Ten-thousand English Compositions of Chinese Learners Corpus accessed at <http://114.251.154.212/cqp/teccl/> (the username and password: test)
3. *He or she* has many variants, including *she or he*, *he/she*, *she/he*, *s/he*, *he(she)*, *she(he)*, *(s)he*, and their objective/ possessive/reflective forms.
4. This corpus can be freely accessed at <http://114.251.154.212/cqp/iwritebaby/> (the username and password: test)
5. This string of letters and numbers denotes the identifying number assigned to each essay in the iWriteBaby corpus.

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